

Silphion proved difficult to cultivate and was gathered from the wild in such large quantities that it became extinct during the 3rd century CE.

Today, if herbal medicine continues to grow at its present rate, it is imperative that manufacturers, suppliers, practitioners, and the public use only produce that has been cultivated or wildcrafted in an ecologically sensitive manner.

About This Book

In the past, books on herbal medicine have tended to focus either on the traditional and folkloric use of plants or on their active constituents and pharmacology. *The Encyclopedia of Herbal Medicine*, which features over 550 plants, aims to cover both aspects. It discusses each plant's history, traditions, and folklore, and explains in simple terms what is known from scientific research about its active constituents, actions, and potential new uses.

It is easy when concentrating on the scientific aspect of herbal medicine to forget that much, in some cases *all*, that we currently know about a particular plant results from its traditional use. Moreover, even when a plant has been well researched, herbal medicines are so complex and variable that what is currently known is rarely definitive, but rather a sound pointer as to how it works. Sometimes the traditional use, insofar as it is based on the experience of practitioners, provides an insight into how best to use an herb that is missing from scientific knowledge alone. Herbal medicine is, after all, both a science *and* an art.

In choosing the plants profiled in the *Encyclopedia*, the aim has been to select herbs that are commonly used in different parts of the world and are considered to have particular health benefits. The index of key medicinal plants (pp. 54–155) contains many herbs that are readily available in health stores and pharmacies, for example St. John's wort (*Hypericum perforatum*, p. 106). It also includes herbs that are more commonly known as foods, such as lemon (*Citrus limon*, p. 82), but which, nonetheless, are valuable medicines. The index of other medicinal plants (pp. 156–283) contains some less commonly known but important medicinal herbs, such as andrographis (*Andrographis paniculata*, p. 167), a traditional Indian medicinal plant that stimulates recovery from infection and supports normal liver function.

A global overview of the history of herbal medicine puts the development of different herbal traditions from earliest origins to the present day into perspective. This is complemented with features on herbal medicine in Europe, India, China, Africa, Australia, and the Americas, providing a rounded picture of herbal medicine worldwide.

Herbal medicine is nothing if not practical in its approach, and the *Encyclopedia* has a detailed self-help section with advice on preparing and using herbal medicines to treat a range of common health problems.

If more people come to appreciate the immense richness of the world of herbal medicine and are able to benefit from the curative properties of medicinal herbs, this book will have achieved its aim.

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